E Minor

Scale Practice Worksheet · 1 sharp (F♯) · 4 octaves

Key Signatures

Natural minor — 1 sharp: F♯

Harmonic minor — 2 sharps: F♯, D♯

Melodic minor — 3 sharps: F♯, C♯, D♯ (ascending); reverts to natural descending

SCALES

01 Scale — Parallel Motion

Practice E natural minor, harmonic minor, and melodic minor across 4 octaves, both hands moving in the same direction.

TIP
For melodic minor, the raised 6th and 7th (C♯, D♯) alter the feel on the way up. Be deliberate — don't let the hand revert to natural minor out of habit. Natural minor descending.

02 Scale — Contrary Motion

Same scale, hands moving in opposite directions simultaneously. Both hands begin on E, one ascending and one descending.

TIP
Harder than parallel motion. Excellent brain training. Add contrary motion to any exercise in this worksheet for an extra challenge.

03 Scale in Sixths

Play the E harmonic minor scale in sixths — notes a sixth apart in each hand simultaneously.

The left hand begins on G, the 3rd scale degree, rather than the root. Start slower than you think you need. Apply contrary motion once parallel motion is stable.

04 Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply these to any scale exercise for fluidity and evenness. Build from the simplest grouping upward — do not jump straight to the hardest.

a Accent every [quarter] note — deliberate weight on each individual note.

b Accent every second [eighth] note — a grouped, rolling feel.

c Triplet groupings — organize the scale in threes.

d Accent every fourth note [sixteenth] — groups of four.

e Accent every seventh note — the most advanced grouping.

> **TIP**
> Rhythm gives your scale playing structure. Without it, you lose your place on the keyboard. Grouping in sevens helps you play at faster tempos — it organizes a long run into manageable units.

05 Scale in Thirds

Play the E minor scale in harmonic thirds — two notes a third apart, both hands together. Include contrary motion.

> **TIP**
> Isolate the left hand if it feels unclear. Do not combine hands until each hand is stable alone.

06 Chords — Warm-Up

Begin with solid three-note chords (**E** – **G** – **B**) before adding the octave. This is the recommended opening when sitting down cold — slow, comfortable, no tension.

Option A (easier): Three-note chord only — E, G, B together.

Option B (full): Four-note chord held inside a full octave span.

Both versions produce the same musical result. Choose based on where your hands are at the start of the session.

> **TECHNIQUE**
> Chords are about releasing weight into the keyboard, not pressing down with force. Drop the arm weight. The goal is a full, fat sound — not a tense, pushed one. Sit at the edge of the bench so your weight transfers forward into the keys.

07 Arpeggios — Short

Play three-note **E** – **G** – **B** broken triads across 4 octaves. Root position, 1st inversion, 2nd inversion. Both hands.

> **TECHNIQUE**
> Use circular arm motion. Feel the weight of the arm dropping naturally into each note. Stay close to the keyboard — the all-white-key surface offers no raised black key landmarks to guide you back in.

08 Broken Chords

Play four-note **E** – **G** – **B** – **E** in broken form (notes separated, not struck together) across the keyboard, moving through all inversions.

> **TIP**
> Practice left hand alone first. On an all-white-key surface, thumb crossing requires deliberate attention. Move your body with your hands — reaching from the shoulder alone creates tension and inaccuracy.

09 Long Arpeggios

Extended arpeggios **E – G – B – E – G – B – E** across the full keyboard. Root position, 1st inversion, 2nd inversion. Add contrary motion once stable.

Separate hands before combining — this exposes weaknesses that disappear when both hands play together.

Stay close to the key surface at all times. On an all-white-key scale, lifting fingers too far causes missed notes — there are no raised black keys to orient your hand.

TRAINING THUMB-UNDER

Hold any finger (2nd, 3rd, or 4th) down and practice spreading the thumb away and back repeatedly, expanding the interval gradually. This motion — not strength — is what long arpeggios require. Move the center of your body with your hands rather than reaching with the arms alone.

SIX-CHORD SEQUENCE

10 Six-Chord Sequence (starting from E major)

Always start from the major tonic, even when practicing a minor key. The standard sequence for E minor:

1) **E major** — I (root position)

2) **E minor** — i (root position)

3) **C major** — VI (1st inversion)

4) **C♯ minor** — ♯vi (1st inversion)

5) **A major** — IV (2nd inversion)

6) **A minor** — iv (2nd inversion)

TIP

Slow first, then increase speed. Learn I – i – VI – ♯vi – IV – iv as a transferable formula, not a sequence to memorize per key.

JAZZ CHORD EXTENSIONS

11 Minor Seventh & Major Seventh Chords

Extend the tonic chord with jazz voicings. These shapes are deliberately unfamiliar — that is the point.

Em7 — E – G – B – D (minor seventh)

Emaj7 — E – G♯ – B – D♯ (major seventh — larger hand stretch)

For smaller hands: play the three-note inner voicing without the bass octave. This is standard jazz practice and produces the correct sound.

> TIP
> Practicing unfamiliar shapes trains the hand to locate positions it does not yet know. Apply the same weight and tone approach as the classical chords above. Apply the same broken-chord and arpeggio variations as exercises 7–9.

DOMINANT — B7

12 B7 Exercises (Arpeggios, Broken Chords, Chords, Long Arpeggios)

Repeat exercises 7–9 using **B – D♯ – F♯ – A** (V7 of E minor). Play through all inversions: root, 1st, 2nd, 3rd.

Warm-up: Octave first, then add the inner three voices one at a time.

> TIP
> The four-note stretch is larger than the tonic triad. Do not play dominant seventh exercises at the very start of warm-up. The hand shape is irregular — some intervals are close, others wide — and requires care.

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13 Double Thirds — Introduction

Double thirds are two simultaneous thirds played in each hand, moving up and down the scale. The most demanding exercise in this worksheet.

The left and right hand fingering move in near-synchronicity in E minor, which makes coordination easier than in most other keys.

Identify where the 5th finger lands at each position first — that is the anchor point. Everything else organizes around it. Start in two octaves before attempting four. Fingering is personal — adjust what does not suit your hand.

13a Double Thirds — Single Voice Isolation

Before playing both voices simultaneously, remove one voice and practice with the other alone — using the exact fingering you would use for the full double third.

Step 1 — Play the lower voice only, with its double-third fingering.

Step 2 — Play the upper voice only, with its double-third fingering.

Step 3 — Hold the lower voice and play the upper voice moving.

Step 4 — Hold the upper voice and play the lower voice moving.

> TIP
> Do not simplify the fingering in these preparatory steps.

13b Double Thirds — Hands Separately

Practice left hand alone, then right hand alone, before combining.

Aim for legato connection between notes — this is genuinely difficult in double thirds, but it is the goal even if full legato is not yet achievable. Use all fingers actively. The 5th finger must be included — do not avoid it.

13c Double Thirds — Hands Together

Combine both hands once each is stable separately.

> TIP
> Even when hands are individually secure, the combined version will feel different. This is normal. Return to separate-hand practice whenever coordination breaks down.

FINISHING

14 Chromatic Scale

Play the chromatic scale starting from E across the full keyboard. A good way to close out your session and clear the hand after demanding work.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- E minor has one more black key than C or A minor. This gives your hand better landmarks — F# especially helps anchor your position. The scale sits comfortably under the hand.
- Begin every session slowly. Start with simple chords before playing anything fast. The first thing you play sets the tension level for everything that follows.
- Practice separate hands for arpeggios and inversions. Combining hands too early hides individual weaknesses.
- Playing unfamiliar chord shapes and positions is productive. Mistakes in new territory mean the hand is learning something it does not yet know.
- All-white-key scales have no raised landmarks. Fingering must be learned deliberately — you cannot rely on the black keys to reorient your hand.
- Sit at the edge of the bench. Weight should transfer forward into the keyboard — not backward into the chair.
- Train the thumb with dedicated isolation exercises. It is the main difficulty in all-white-key long arpeggios.
- Always aim for 4 octaves across the full keyboard.